PROactive PRONUNCIATION

Z Plurals

Pronunciation of “s” pronounced as /s/

Rule #1: /S/

When? After VOICELESS sounds.

If the sound just before the plural “s” is VOICELESS, the plural “s” will continue to be voiceless: It will stay a /s/ (also VOICELESS).

So plural words that end in the voiceless sounds /p/, /t/, /k/, /f/, /θ/ would stay an /s/!

Examples:

grapes /s/

bits /s/

weeks /s/

backs /s/

briefs /s/

baths /s/

Pronunciation of “s” pronounced as /z/

When? After VOICED sounds.

Rule #2: /Z/

If the sound just before the plural "s" is VOICED, the plural "s" will continue to be voiced: We will pronounce the "s" as a voiced /z/.

So words that end in the voiced sounds /b/, /d/, /g/, /L/, /r/, /w/, /m/, /n/, /v/, /y/,/ð/ and all vowels (ALL ARE VOICED) turn into a /z/!

Examples:

cribs /z/

beds /z/

pigs /z/
bells /z/
jars /z/
straws /z/
clams /z/
fans /z/
doves /z/
delays /z/
teethes /z/

Pronunciation of “s” pronounced as /IZ/

When? After /s/ /z/ “sh” “ch” and “j” sounds.

Rule #3: /IZ/

Now, this might sound confusing, and you might be asking why? We add a vowel /ɪ/ with the /z/because it's a way to separate the /z/ from another sound that is too similar. We might lose the meaning of the plural if we don’t do this. So, we wouldn't say "mass> massss"; it would be "masses" or /mæsɪz/.

Examples:

wishes /ɪz/
flashes /ɪz/
watches /ɪz/
witches /ɪz/
bridges /ɪz/
judges /ɪz/
slices /ɪz/
classes /ɪz/
blazes /ɪz/